

The Third Coming

The arithmetic of caste, pro-farmer policies and a fractured opposition help the Congress-NCP combine score a hat-trick

By Swati Mathur, Jhilmil Motihar and Malini Bhupta

Pol Khol screamed the frontpage headline in Shiv Sena's mouth-piece *Saamna* on October 22. Promising a mini expose of sorts, Bal Thackeray's famous editorial rubbished findings of most exit polls. To him, a higher voter turnout in the assembly elections meant that Maharashtra had voted for change. As it turns out, the Marathi *manoos* has voted not for change but for the same, yet again. Thackeray Senior will have to live with his beard for another five years.

So impressive is the Congress's showing that for the first time since 1990, the state has a ruling front with a clear majority of 144 seats. The return is a record hat-trick for the third consecutive term with the Congress winning 82 seats of the 174 it contested and its ally, the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), bagging 62 seats of the 114 helped by the arithmetic of caste, the minority vote and a fractured opposition. Significantly, NCP

chief Sharad Pawar has proved that he is still the grand Maratha of Maharashtra, delivering a strike rate of over 50 per cent. Indeed, those who argued that Congress should have fought the poll alone citing the poor performance of the NCP in the Lok Sabha polls have been silenced.

Ironically, the tally of both the BJP and the Shiv Sena who were courting Independents and rebels till October 22 morning is the lowest in 15 years and the irony is that the Shiv Sena, which has always been the leading ally despite contesting 169 seats, has won fewer seats than the BJP. Such was the momentum that by 10.30 a.m. BJP leader Gopinath Munde had thrown in the towel by admitting defeat.

On the face of it, this could have been a template campaign for the Opposition. Terror at-

tacks, farmer suicides, 26/11, the floods and price rise besides a 10-year reign would have been fodder for any opposition front. Sure, the Centre's policies of higher credit, procurement prices and debt waive for farmers helped. But nothing that the Shiv Sena or the BJP said or campaigned on stayed with the voters. As it turns out the Opposition converted it into an issue-less election. The BJP, preoccupied with its internal civil war, and the Shiv Sena with its very public fratricidal war with the Raj Thackeray-led Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS), it was BJP vs BJP and Thackeray vs Thackeray, leaving the field clear for the Congress-NCP combine.

Such has been the ferocity of the battle that every other issue,



SHARAD PAWAR, SONIA GANDHI AND ASHOK CHAVAN AT AN ELECTION RALLY

THE RULING FRONT HAS HARVESTED THE RAJ rebellion. For the first time since 1990, Maharashtra has a ruling front with a clear majority in the House.